



Figure 4: Global traffic statistics illustration by Ntop (Image credits: Google Images)

1. It helps in network flows and local traffic analysis.
2. It provides multi-thread and multi-processor support on UNIX and Win32.
3. The Python lightweight API can be used for extending Ntop via scripts.
4. It supports both NetFlow and Flow as a flow collector. It can simultaneously collect from more than one probe.
5. The traffic statistics obtained are saved into RRD databases for long-run analysis.
6. It also helps in getting Internet domain, VLAN (virtual LAN) and AS (autonomous systems) statistics.
7. The discovery and categorisation of network assets are done according to their operating system and users.
8. It consists of various protocol decoders for many Internet protocols.
9. It provides RRD support for storing per-host traffic information, persistently.
10. It supports virtual or multiple network interfaces. The platforms supported by Ntop are:
 1. UNIX (including Linux, Solaris, *BSD and MacOSX)
 2. Win32 (Win95 and above, including Vista)

Factors considered by Windows sys admins while choosing an open source tool

Prior to purchasing any product in the market, several factors need to be considered. The cost factor would be one of the most significant, but Windows sys admins need not bother about this as open source tools are available free of cost. So let's examine what other factors ought to be considered before opting for any open source tool.

1. The performance and efficiency of the tool is one of the most important aspects. One has to check whether the tool under consideration fulfils all requirements completely or not.
2. A cross-platform tool is what most Windows sys admins prefer.
3. It should be easy to learn and understand the tool so that it can be implemented and modified easily to meet specific requirements.

4. The tool should be highly secure.
5. Windows admins would also prefer a tool that has proper support available for it.

The security aspect of open source tools for Windows sys admins

Information security is one of the biggest challenges as well as priorities for Windows sys admins. The security of information or data depends a lot on the software or tools in use. The trustworthiness of any tool, either open source or closed source, depends on some key aspects of how the tool was designed and developed. These include:

1. The expertise developers have to develop a secure tool.
2. The security testing processes carried out before the tool is released.
3. The quality of code used in the tool.
4. Various mature practices followed through the development cycle.

Once the open source software tool is made available to the public, anyone and everyone interested in the tool should be able to review the source code to assess its quality and reliability. As it allows a greater number of users and experts to go through the source code, the bugs threatening its security can be discovered and fixed early. Though open source tools have the potential to be more secure than their closed source counterparts, there should be a proper evaluation of their security parameters before implementing them.

Advantages of open source tools

The various advantages of open source tools for Windows sys admins are:

1. They are more reliable as there are fewer chances of leakage in them.
2. No vendor dependence.
3. Free of cost for use.
4. They provide sys admins the flexibility to customise the code for site-specific needs.
5. Windows admins can get a feel of the tools before actually implementing them.
6. They are more secure. 

References

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